

Rebirth as Doctrine and Experience

person will be reborn where (or near where) he dies.” Francis Story needed no reminding that other things are rarely equal. Nevertheless he sensed that regular processes govern rebirth and that further investigations might allow us to develop at least provisional concepts of their “laws.”

If a reader of the present volume should happen to come to it with no knowledge of what Francis Story called “the case for rebirth” he will not put it down without being cured of that ignorance. And although the essays and case reports of this book may not convince anyone of the truth of rebirth—their author never intended that they should—they will at least leave no doubt in his mind that the cases provide some evidence—however future generations may weigh it—which justifies a belief in rebirth. Belief can precede proof and often does.

During the past three or more centuries, since the beginning of European colonialism in South Asia, hundreds of thousands of Europeans have lived in the area as administrators, diplomats, soldiers, traders, or missionaries, and in other capacities. These persons were surrounded by abundant cases of the rebirth type. And yet of all these thousands of Europeans only a handful paid any attention to the cases. One thinks of Fielding Hall and W.F. Yeats-Brown (both of whom gave short summaries of some cases in their books) and—who else? The list is pitifully short. But Francis Story is on it and in my opinion is its most outstanding member to date. The modern anthropologists have been no more attentive to the cases since nearly all have gone to Asia as captives of Western ideas on human personality. On furlough from their doctrinal prisons in Europe or America they could not see in Asia what they knew to be impossible. Francis Story was a different type. Here was a man who did his own thinking and who lived among South Asians not with the idea of teaching them something—although he could—but with that of learning from them. He penetrated farther than any of his predecessors into what I call the empirical basis of South Asian religions. I predict that his contributions to the scientific investigations of rebirth will make his name better known and remembered with gratitude by future generations.

IAN STEVENSON, M.D.

Division of Parapsychology
Department of Psychiatry
School of Medicine
University of Virginia
Charlottesville, Virginia 22901